Tehran, and prompted the shah to ask Norman ‘whether withdrawal of British troops indicated that His Majesty’s Government had ceased to take any interest in Persia’.[33] While the British minister tried to reassure that this was not the case, such worry was understandable.[34] The presence of its troops on Persian soil had been a crucial component of Britain’s policy since their arrival there during the First World War. Curzon himself had argued throughout 1919 and 1920 that Norperforce was instrumental in preventing a Bolshevik penetration of Persia.[35] Thus, by removing its troops, Britain was potentially opening the door for Soviet Russia to gain an ascendancy in Persia. Norman for one firmly believed that the removal of Norperforce ‘will be immediately followed by a Bolshevik occupation, or, at least, by arrival of numerous Bolshevik agents’ into the country.[36]

Nor was the British minister alone in his fears. The head of the Persian Imperial Bank believed that for Britain ‘to desert before we are compelled by force...will be simply doing what [the] Moscow Government are anxious we might do’.[37] The India Office too, was anxious about what the recall of Britain’s troops would mean for the growth of Bolshevik influence in Persia. As Montagu explained to Chelmsford, any Bolshevik advance into that country:

would not necessarily take [the] form of military invasion. More probably it would follow customary line of political propaganda among disaffected elements of [the] population...We must therefore be prepared, if we withdraw from Persia...to see [the] whole country fall under direct Bolshevik influences, which will then extend right up to [the] frontiers of India and Mesopotamia.[38]

In Hardinge’s opinion, Britain was ‘simply throwing away the fruit of a hundred years of effort in Persia for the sake of the withdrawal of three or four thousand men.’[39]

The viceroy, however, was one of the few who did not share these concerns. Since 1918, Chelmsford had been advocating a reduced role for Britain in